

Scaling-Up Farm Businesses to Support Thriving Local Food Systems

Insights from a convening of producers and food supply chain stakeholders from the North Alabama local food system.

Shared Vision for the Future Agrifood System

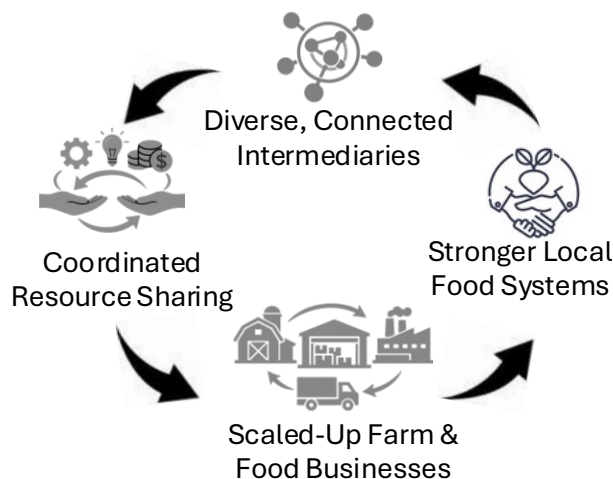
A thriving local agrifood system that connects a multitude of diverse intermediaries to provide opportunities to pool resources to scale individual farm businesses and offer local food to eaters/buyers at affordable prices.

Why This Matters

Local food systems can improve:

- Rural economic resilience
- Food access and nutrition
- Regional supply chain stability
- Climate and environmental sustainability

Yet producers, supply chain intermediaries, and eaters/buyers **remain disconnected**, which results in **gaps in supply chain facilities and missed opportunities to cooperate**.



Key Barriers Identified



Unknown demand from local food buyers

No systematic way to know current and future needs of local buyers so producers can meet—and help steer—those needs with local produce.



Creating new demand is time-intensive

Direct marketing and social media promotion to reach new consumers requires more time and labor that small farmers often lack.



Pathways from cottage to commercial production

Lack of strategies for scaling from cottage to commercial food production through outlets such as restaurants, grocery stores, or regional distributors.



Competition with conventional food systems

Conventional food systems have significant economies of scale and policy/lobbying advantages that make direct competition largely ineffective.



Few resource providers for small farms

Agencies or resource providers lack knowledge about smaller-scale farm operations and specific growing regions, resulting in missed opportunities for needed support.

Community-Driven Solutions for Strengthening Local Food Systems + supporting agrifood system stakeholders

1. Diversify Local Food System Intermediaries

Incorporate more, diverse supply chain intermediaries to increase coordinated opportunities for decentralized services and resource sharing (e.g., food hubs, cold storage and/or kitchen capacity at churches, schools).

2. Strengthen Community Relationships

Build community relationships among producers, supply chain intermediaries, eaters/buyers to increase demand, enable more personal marketing opportunities, and leverage collective resources for scaling up.

3. Focus on Existing Demand for Local Food

Prioritize identifying and tapping into existing demand for local food, since the time/resources required to generate new demand may not have the same payoff.

4. Values-Based Marketing of Local Food

Promote the benefits, quality, and seasonal nature of local food while appealing to values-based consumers that demand an alternative food system rather than competing directly with the conventional food system.

5. Establish Local Food Councils

Food councils can coordinate infrastructure investments, policy support, and collaboration across food system actors.

6. Expand Research on Local Food Markets

More research is needed to identify barriers to local market growth, supply chain gaps, successful models from other regions, and opportunities for scaling local food demand.



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Workshop Information

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